Voting Patterns in Alberta's 2026 Referendum

Joseph Chung Zarif Masud Amina-Nasree Mohamed Lewis Sang

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Abstract

The Alberta 2026 Referendum is emblematic of the changing and polarising political landscape within the province. In this paper we asked how the voting patterns across Alberta's October 2026 referendum questions reflect the ideological diversity and historical realignment of Alberta's conservative political landscape. The results and votes were collected from Elections Alberta and mapped across the 10 questions and electoral divisions. This paper demonstrates the geopolitical divisions in the province within the largest context of political conservatism in the legislature, particularly along the lines of urban and rural populations.

1 Introduction

Alberta's recent October 2026 referendum presented voters with ten questions addressing a range of political and constitutional issues, including immigration policy, provincial jurisdiction, federal-provincial relations, and the possibility of pursuing separation from Canada. Instead of asking voters to endorse a single political proposition, the referendum presented a series of confusing questions regarding Alberta's relationship with the Canadian constitution and the direction of provincial policy. The resulting voting patterns provide an opportunity to examine how Albertans responded to these different political concerns and whether support for particular measures corresponded with support for broader constitutional change.

The modern separatist campaign is typically associated with modern alt-right movements, particularly the 2022 Freedom Convoy. However, the movement also arises from a longer provincial history of contention with the federal government, as well as broader class and cultural divides between the urban and rural populations. Alongside the United Conservative Party (UCP) and their implementation of increasingly authoritarian policies, the October 2026 referendum offers a particularly poignant snapshot into Alberta's current political landscape. Who is interested in the idea of separation? Who aligns with UCP's policies outside of the "ticket issues?"

This paper examines voting patterns across the ten referendum questions to investigate how support varied between distinct policy and constitutional objectives, and how these patterns were distributed geographically. It queries whether differences in support suggest that voters distinguished between particular conservative policy positions and broader demands for provincial autonomy or constitutional change. It further situates these patterns within the historical realignment of Alberta's conservative political movement, examining the extent to which the UCP's ideological diversity and political messaging may help explain the divergence between voting preferences across the referendum.

The central research question guiding this paper asks how the voting patterns across Alberta's October 2026 referendum questions reflect the ideological diversity and historical realignment of Alberta's conservative political landscape. This question is addressed through two secondary questions:

1. How did voting patterns vary across the ten referendum questions, and what differences emerged between support for immigration-related measures, constitutional reforms, and the question of separation from Canada?
2. To what extent did voting patterns vary geographically across electoral divisions, and what patterns of support and opposition can be identified?

2 Background

Understanding these voting patterns requires attention to the historical development of Alberta's political landscape. The province has a longstanding tradition of political uniqueness, shaped by disputes over federal authority, resource governance, regional representation, and provincial autonomy. These tensions have been articulated through a number of political movements, including the Reform Party, the Wildrose Party, and, more recently, the United Conservative Party (UCP). The formation of the UCP in 2017 brought together the former Progressive Conservative and Wildrose movements, merging Albertan conservatism under a single political umbrella. Under Premier Danielle Smith's leadership, questions of provincial autonomy and resistance to federal authority have assumed renewed prominence.

This political merger raises questions about the ideological composition of contemporary Alberta conservatism. The UCP encompasses a wide range of political beliefs, from mainstream fiscal and social conservatism to populist, nationalist, and most contentiously, sovereigntist positions. Although these traditions share certain political commitments, they do not necessarily align on questions of federalism, constitutional reform, or the future of Alberta within Canada. The party's ability to accommodate these different constituencies within a common political identity is atypical and an important feature when examining the political context of the referendum.

2.1 Populism, Identity, and Layered Alienation

Alberta's contemporary political landscape is rooted in a longer history of regional political distinctiveness, populism, and resistance to perceived external authority. Macpherson's (1953) account of Alberta's quasi-party system and Laycock's (1990) historical analysis of Prairie populism demonstrate that anti-establishment politics and challenges to conventional party structures are not recent developments. Rather, they form part of a political tradition in which appeals to popular sovereignty, individualism, and distrust of established political institutions have repeatedly been mobilized.

Western alienation has been particularly influential in this political history. Disputes over federal authority, resource governance, and the distribution of economic benefits have contributed to a persistent perception that Alberta's interests are insufficiently represented within Confederation. The National Energy Program of 1980 is a significant reference point in the province's political history, as it reinforced the idea of federal interference and regional marginalization. However, it is important to clarify that western alienation is not synonymous with separatism. Alienation is this case is much more broad, encompassing a range of positions, including demands for greater provincial autonomy, opposition to federal policy, and, in some cases, support for independence.

Clark Banack's (2021) ethnographic study of rural Alberta offers a contemporary framework for understanding how these sentiments develop and become politically relevant by emphasizing the role of social identity and belonging in shaping political opinion. His research identifies three overlapping forms of alienation among rural Albertans, specifically western alienation, political alienation among those who identify as "ordinary people," and rural alienation rooted in the perceived marginalization of rural communities. As Banack explains, these forms of alienation are often experienced as "being layered, frequently melting into each other"(2021, 4).

This concept of layered alienation is important because it suggests that political grievances extend beyond the particular issues from which they originate. Banack finds that a sense of being overlooked as Albertans, seemingly excluded from political decision-making as ordinary citizens, and misunderstood as rural residents can converge into a broader perception of political and social marginalization. In his account, these identities help explain why individuals may connect seemingly unrelated political concerns through a common understanding of who is being represented, who is being ignored, and whose interests are being prioritized.

Banack's findings complicate conventional explanations of conservative political attitudes as his participants consistently articulated a shared moral vocabulary centred on "common sense, hard work, self-reliance" and being "down-to-earth" (2021, 13). These values were understood as defining characteristics of rural community identity and the resulting political outlook combined elements of libertarianism, individual responsibility, community solidarity, and opposition to government intervention. This demonstrates that conservative

political identification can encompass different, and sometimes potentially oppositional, expectations of government. For example, a preference for limited government can coexist with demands that provincial institutions defend local industries, communities, and regional interests.

Banack further demonstrates how these overlapping identities can shape interpretations of immigration and Indigenous policy. Participants frequently connected their own perceived marginalization to the belief that governments were directing resources and attention toward other groups while neglecting rural communities. He notes that resentment toward newcomers and Indigenous peoples was sometimes articulated through a moral framework emphasizing hard work, self-reliance, and equal treatment (2021, 17–19). Though this does not mean that all rural Albertans share these attitudes, nor that such views characterize Alberta conservatism as a whole, it does illustrate quite clearly how political grievances that are associated with regional and social identity can also become connected to broader anti-establishment and exclusionary political attitudes.

2.2 UCP Ideological Consolidation

The transformation of Alberta's conservative party system provides a second important context for understanding the province's contemporary political landscape. For much of its modern political history, Alberta was characterized by the dominance of a single conservative governing party. The Progressive Conservatives maintained power from 1971 until their defeat by the NDP in 2015. However, the emergence of the Wildrose Alliance challenged this political arrangement by creating a vehicle for conservative constituencies dissatisfied with the Progressive Conservative establishment.

Sayers and Stewart (2011) identify the strategic challenge facing Wildrose as its attempt to move beyond a more narrowly defined political base and become a broader electoral coalition. They describe the party's ambition to transform itself from a "fringe right wing party" into a "broad coalition capable of appealing to a large number of Albertans" (2011, 1). Their analysis identifies a tension within Alberta conservatism, namely the effort to mobilize anti-establishment and populist constituencies while also appealing to a wider electorate. The party drew upon political traditions associated with individualism, populist understandings of government, wariness of federal authority, and support for core public services.

The formation of the United Conservative Party in 2017 brought the Progressive Conservative and Wildrose movements together under a single political organization. This consolidation was deeply significant and transformed party politics at the time, but it should not be understood as evidence that the ideological differences between these constituencies disappeared. The UCP brought together different political traditions, including establishment-oriented fiscal conservatism, socially conservative constituencies, populist anti-establishment politics, and more assertive forms of provincial nationalism. Though these positions may overlap, they are definitely not interchangeable. More specifically, support for greater provincial autonomy does not necessarily imply support for constitutional separation or independence. Within the Canadian context, one may even make the case that it rarely means separation or independence except in the case of Québec.

Thus, the development of the UCP raises questions about how political parties manage ideological diversity within an electoral coalition. The UCP's advocacy for greater provincial autonomy has created a pathway to simultaneously aggravate and organize around regional frustrations while maintaining a broader governing coalition. Sayers, McMahon, and Koop (2023), in their analysis of the Alberta Sovereignty Act, examine how autonomy politics can function as an electoral strategy, raising the salience of western alienation and positioning the provincial government in opposition to federal authority. Considering these works alongside Banack's work on layered alienation suggests that the UCP operates within a political environment where distinct grievances can be communicated through a common language of provincial identity and political marginalization.

The party's coalition may encompass voters and political actors who agree that Alberta is insufficiently represented within Confederation but differ in their opinions on how to best address that issue. Some may favour greater provincial control within Canada, while others may support more fundamental constitutional change. The party's ability to accommodate these positions raises the possibility of strategic ambiguity in political messaging where distinct political objectives can be presented as aligned elements of a shared project to defend Alberta without requiring the party to resolve the tensions between them.

These approaches are useful for examining a referendum that contains multiple questions that address different dimensions of provincial politics. Rather than presenting voters with a single issue, the October 2026 referendum asked them to consider extremely specific policy and constitutional questions. These questions provide an opportunity to examine whether patterns of support differ between immigration-related measures, proposals concerning provincial authority and constitutional arrangements, and the question of separation from Canada.

2.3 Political Framing and Referendum Voting

Understanding how competing political traditions are mobilized also requires attention to political framing and the role of parties in shaping public opinion. Populism provides one useful conceptual lens. Mudde (2004) characterizes populism as an ideological framework that divides society between a supposedly unified and virtuous people where appeals to crisis, conflict, and the failure of established institutions help construct political legitimacy. Both approaches are relevant to Alberta politics, where narratives of provincial marginalization can position the federal government and political establishment as external or unresponsive forces.

Banack's (2021) findings add an important element to this discussion as his research suggests that anti-establishment politics can gain traction not only through opposition to particular institutions or policies, but also through a broader sense of social exclusion. Participants frequently expressed frustration that politicians did not listen to ordinary people and that political decisions were controlled by party leadership and political elites. One participant summarized this sentiment by asking, "Where are the grassroots?" (Banack 2021, 11).

Political framing is also important because voters do not necessarily consider referendum questions as separate from the political environment in which they are presented. Zaller's (1992) work on mass opinion demonstrates how elite discourse and the information available to citizens shape the considerations through which political preferences are formed and expressed. Similarly, LeDuc (2003) shows that referendum decisions are influenced by more than the technical content of a proposal. Party identification, political leadership, campaign arguments, and broader ideological considerations can all inform how voters approach direct-democratic questions. Hobolt's (2009) study of European referendums likewise demonstrates the importance of political context and elite cues in shaping referendum outcomes.

3 Methodology

We use the official results of the 19 October 2026 Alberta referendum, published by Elections Alberta for each of the province's 87 electoral divisions (ridings) (Elections Alberta 2026). All quantities are measured at the riding level. The analysis uses Python (Van Rossum and Drake 2009) with pandas (McKinney 2010), GeoPandas (Jordahl et al. 2020) and Matplotlib (Hunter 2007). Every number, table and figure in this paper is produced by `notebooks/06-spatial_analysis.ipynb`.

3.1 Data

3.1.1 Referendum Questions

The referendum featured ten separate ballots, each featuring one of ten questions (Table 1). Questions 1 to 5 asked about immigration in Alberta and regulating access to public services. Questions 6 to 9 asked whether the provincial government should seek constitutional amendments with other provinces in order for provinces to have more governing power. Question 10 asked voters to choose between Alberta remaining a province (Option 1) and the government beginning the legal process for a binding referendum on separation (Option 2), but was not itself binding.

To assess questions as they related to separatist sentiments, **support** was defined as the Yes share for questions 1 to 9 and the Option 2 share for Question 10.

Table 1: The ten referendum questions. Short labels are used in the figures and tables that follow.

Short label	Wording on the ballot
Q1 Immigration control	Do you support the Government of Alberta taking increased control over immigration for the purposes of decreasing immigration to more sustainable levels, prioritizing economic migration and giving Albertans first priority on new employment opportunities?
Q2 Program eligibility	Do you support the Government of Alberta introducing a law mandating that only Canadian citizens, permanent residents and individuals with an Alberta-approved immigration status will be eligible for provincially-funded programs, such as health care, education and other social services?
Q3 Residency wait	Assuming that all Canadian citizens and permanent residents continue to qualify for social support programs as they do now, do you support the Government of Alberta introducing a law requiring all individuals with a non-permanent legal immigration status to reside in Alberta for at least 12 months before qualifying for any provincially-funded social support programs?
Q4 Health/education fee	Assuming that all Canadian citizens and permanent residents continue to qualify for public health care and education as they do now, do you support the Government of Alberta charging a reasonable fee or premium to individuals with a non-permanent immigration status living in Alberta for their and their family's use of the health care and education systems?
Q5 Citizenship to vote	Do you support the Government of Alberta introducing a law requiring individuals to provide proof of citizenship, such as a passport, birth certificate or citizenship card, to vote in an Alberta provincial election?
Q6 Provinces pick judges	Do you support the Government of Alberta working with the governments of other willing provinces to amend the Canadian Constitution to have provincial governments, and not the federal government, select the justices appointed to provincial King's Bench and Appeal courts?
Q7 Abolish Senate	Do you support the Government of Alberta working with the governments of other willing provinces to amend the Canadian Constitution to abolish the unelected federal Senate?
Q8 Opt out with funding	Do you support the Government of Alberta working with the governments of other willing provinces to amend the Canadian Constitution to allow provinces to opt out of federal programs that intrude on provincial jurisdiction such as health care, education and social services, without a province losing any of the associated federal funding for use in its social programs?
Q9 Provincial paramountcy	Do you support the Government of Alberta working with the governments of other willing provinces to amend the Canadian Constitution to better protect provincial rights from federal interference by giving a province's laws dealing with provincial or shared areas of constitutional jurisdiction priority over federal laws when the province's laws and federal laws conflict?
Q10 Separation process	Should Alberta remain a province of Canada, or should the Government of Alberta commence the legal process required under the Canadian Constitution to hold a binding provincial referendum on whether or not Alberta should separate from Canada?

3.1.2 Electoral Divisions

The division-level workbooks were cleaned into one row per division and question. For every question only valid votes were used, the sum of the two choices, and excluded declined and rejected ballots. The cleaned totals match the provincial figures in Elections Alberta's 29 October 2026 news release exactly for Question 10, and to within about 100 votes on every other question (the largest gap is on Question 7, where the workbooks and the news release disagree).

Division boundaries are based on the 2017 electoral divisions from the Government of Alberta's geospatial service (Government of Alberta 2017). The boundaries were simplified on download (to a tolerance of 0.002 degrees) and repaired where simplification left invalid polygons. Results and boundaries are joined by division number, not name, because one division is named Calgary-McCall in the boundary file and Calgary-Bhullar-McCall in the results.

Each riding is assigned to one of five regions (Figure 1). Calgary and Edmonton contain only the ridings within those cities; suburbs and nearby towns such as St. Albert, Sherwood Park, Airdrie and Chestermere are part of Central. These labels were carried over from an earlier exploratory notebook and have not been checked against an official classification.

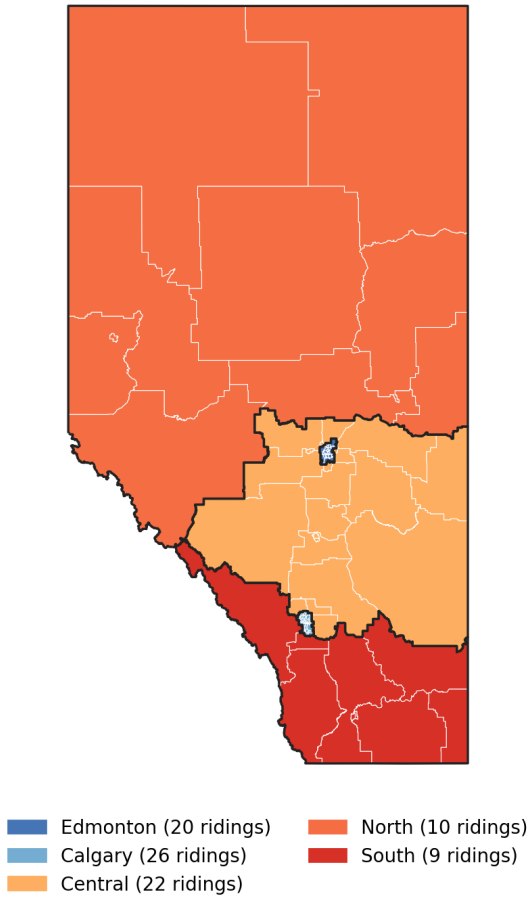


Figure 1: The five regions used in the analysis. Thin white lines are riding boundaries; dark lines are region boundaries. Calgary (26 ridings) and Edmonton (20) are the small areas inside Central and South.

To compare the referendum with political party affiliation, Elections Alberta's official results for the 2019 and 2023 provincial general elections (Elections Alberta 2023) were used, which were held on the same 2017 boundaries. A party's share in each riding is calculated by its votes as a percentage of valid ballots. In each riding, the candidate votes sum to the valid ballots, and the provincial totals reproduce the published results (UCP 52.6% and NDP 44.0% in 2023; UCP 54.9% and NDP 32.7% in 2019). Three small parties serve as indicators of separatist sentiment: the Alberta Independence Party in 2019, which ran in 63 ridings; and The Independence Party of Alberta and the Wildrose Independence Party in 2023, which together ran in 15. Where a party had no candidate, the riding is excluded from this analysis.

Turnout was calculated by ballots cast divided by the elector count printed in the division workbooks. Those

elector counts are higher than the count in the news release, so riding-level turnouts are a few points below the headline provincial figure of 70.4%.

3.2 Spatial Dependence

Neighbours are defined by **queen contiguity**: two ridings are neighbours if their boundaries touch at an edge or a corner. To absorb small gaps left by boundary simplification, ridings within 500 m of each other in NAD83 / Alberta 10-TM (a metric projection) are treated as touching. Every riding has at least one neighbour. The weights matrix W is row-standardised. As a sensitivity check we also use the 3, 5, 7 and 10 nearest ridings, measured between centroids in the same projection.

Global clustering is measured with Moran's I (Moran 1950),

$$I = \frac{n}{\sum_i \sum_j w_{ij}} \cdot \frac{\sum_i \sum_j w_{ij}(y_i - \bar{y})(y_j - \bar{y})}{\sum_i (y_i - \bar{y})^2},$$

where y_i is the outcome in riding i. Significance comes from a permutation test: the observed values are reassigned to ridings at random 9,999 times, and the one-sided p-value is the share of permutations with an I at least as large as observed (so the smallest attainable value is 0.0001).

Ridings in the same region are both similar and adjacent, so a high Moran's I could reflect regional differences alone. To separate the two, we subtract each region's mean from its ridings and compute Moran's I on the residuals, which measures clustering *within* regions.

Local clustering uses local Moran's I (Anselin 1995). Each riding is classified by its own standardised value and the average of its neighbours' as High-High (a hotspot), Low-Low (a coldspot), High-Low or Low-High. Significance uses conditional permutation: the riding's own value is held fixed and its neighbours are replaced by random draws from the other ridings, 9,999 times. Ridings with a pseudo p-value of 0.05 or more are reported as not significant. With 87 tests at this level about four false positives are expected by chance, so we interpret the overall pattern rather than individual borderline ridings.

3.3 Comparing the Ten Questions

Agreement between questions is measured by the Pearson correlation of riding-level support across the 87 ridings, and by the share of total variance captured by the first principal component of the ten-by-ten correlation matrix. Region-level support is computed from summed votes, so ridings with both higher populations or votes carry more weight.

To find ridings where Question 10 departed from the rest of the ballot, each riding's Question 10 support on its average support was regressed across questions 1 to 9, using a quadratic fit because the relationship curves at low levels of support. The residual is the riding's **departure**: the number of percentage points by which its Question 10 result was above or below what its other answers predict. It was tested whether departures are themselves clustered with Moran's I. A **carry-over ratio**, Question 10 support divided by average support on questions 1 to 9, was calculated to express how much of a riding's support for the other proposals extended to separation.

3.4 Provincial Party Affiliation

For each question, the correlation across ridings between support and the UCP's 2023 share is measured, and the difference between them: how far a question's support ran above or below the governing party's own vote in the same place. Region-level differences use summed votes for both the referendum and the election. To test whether the party vote accounts for the referendum's geography, we fit Question 10 support on the 2023 UCP share with a quadratic and compute Moran's I on the residuals, as for the departures above.

To test whether past votes mark the ridings that departed from the pattern on Question 10, the departures were correlated with five election measures: the Alberta Independence Party share in 2019, the combined share

of the two 2023 independence parties, the Freedom Conservative Party share in 2019, the change in the UCP share from 2019 to 2023, and the UCP share in 2023. Significance comes from 9,999 random permutations of one variable, two-sided. We report all five tests and make no correction for multiple comparisons, so individual p-values near 0.05 should be read with caution.

Elections and referendums have different electorates and turnout, three years apart. A riding's referendum support falling below its UCP share does not show that UCP voters in that riding voted against a proposal; it shows that the proposal did worse there than the party had.

4 Results

4.1 Question 10

Option 2 received 520,233 votes to Option 1's 1,556,316, or 25.1% of valid votes. It won a majority in 2 of 87 ridings, Rimbey-Rocky Mountain House-Sundre (50.9%) and Central Peace-Notley (50.5%), both by less than one percentage point. Its weakest result was 9.3% in Edmonton-Strathcona.

The metropolitan ridings had the lowest share of Option 2 votes (Figure 2) - no riding in Calgary or Edmonton gave Option 2 more than 23.3%, below the provincial result, while the median North riding gave it 41.0% and the median Central riding 32.0%. Every one of the 20 strongest ridings for Option 2 would be considered "rural."

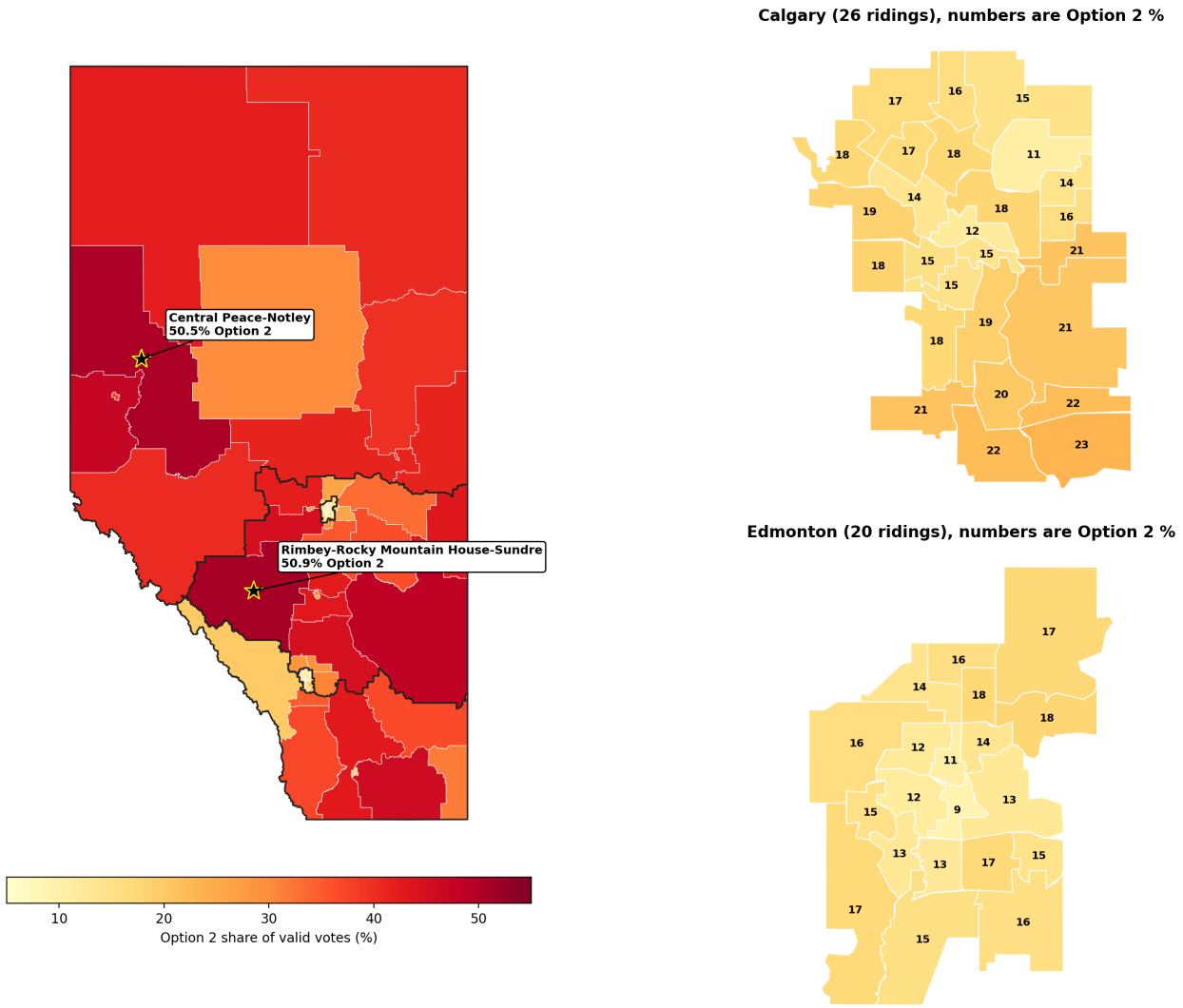


Figure 2: Option 2 share of valid votes on Question 10, by riding, with Calgary and Edmonton enlarged (numbers are Option 2 percentages). Stars mark the two ridings where Option 2 won a majority.

A map coloured by riding overstates Option 2, because the ridings most strongly supporting separatism are also of the greatest area (Figure 3). The North covers 68% of Alberta's land area but cast 8.5% of valid votes. Calgary and Edmonton together cover well under 1% of the land but cast 52% of valid votes, and even with low Option 2 shares they supplied 34% of all Option 2 votes. The largest single source of Option 2 votes was Central Alberta, with 39% of the total from 29% of the vote. The largest block of the separation vote, in other words, came from Central Alberta, the rural areas, towns and suburbs between and around the two cities, rather than from the sparsely populated north.

It is worth noting that this difference in area and population is, in some part, intentional. Central-Peace Notley and Lesser Slave Lake, for example, have a population of 27 155 and 26 715, respectively; the average population per electoral division is roughly 49 thousand (Government of Alberta 2023). However, it can be argued that Alberta has historically *overvalued* its rural populations in terms of representation. As part of the 2017 redrawing of the electoral boundaries, rural constituents argued that this imbalance is necessary to meaningfully convey their needs in the legislature and that the population growth would create a bias towards the faster growing cities. The commission argues that this "disproportionate preservation of the rural voice" is unjustifiable, arguing that "the time has come to stop treating differences between rural and

urban Albertans as a main driver in setting the boundaries of electoral divisions" (Bielby et al. 2017).

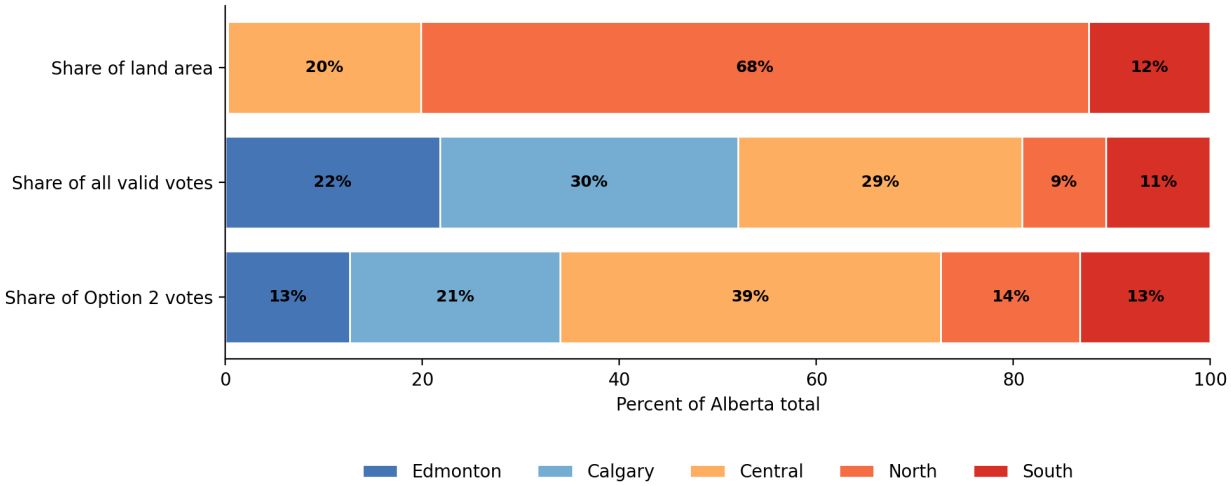


Figure 3: Each region's share of Alberta's land, of all valid votes on Question 10, and of Option 2 votes.

Despite this claim of a interconnected Alberta, the divide between regions remains apparent. Neighbouring ridings voted alike. With shared-border neighbours, Moran's I for the Option 2 share is 0.73. None of the 9,999 random reassignments were similar (the largest was 0.26), giving $p = 0.0001$, the smallest attainable value. The result does not depend on how neighbours are defined: with the 3 to 10 nearest ridings, I ranges from 0.49 to 0.67, falling as more distant ridings are counted as neighbours. Most of this clustering is the difference between regions. After subtracting regional means, Moran's I falls to 0.11 ($p = 0.033$). Some clustering remains within regions, but it is weak: a riding's region predicts most of what its neighbours' results would.

The local analysis shows the shape of the divide (Figure 4). 22 ridings are significant hotspots: every riding in the North (10), 9 in rural Central Alberta and 3 in the southeast around Medicine Hat, Brooks and Cardston. They form one contiguous area. 20 ridings are significant coldspots, all in the older, central parts of Edmonton (12) and Calgary (8). No riding is a significant outlier. The remaining 45 ridings, including the outer city ridings, the suburbs and towns around both cities, Red Deer, Lethbridge and the southwest foothills, sit between the two blocs.

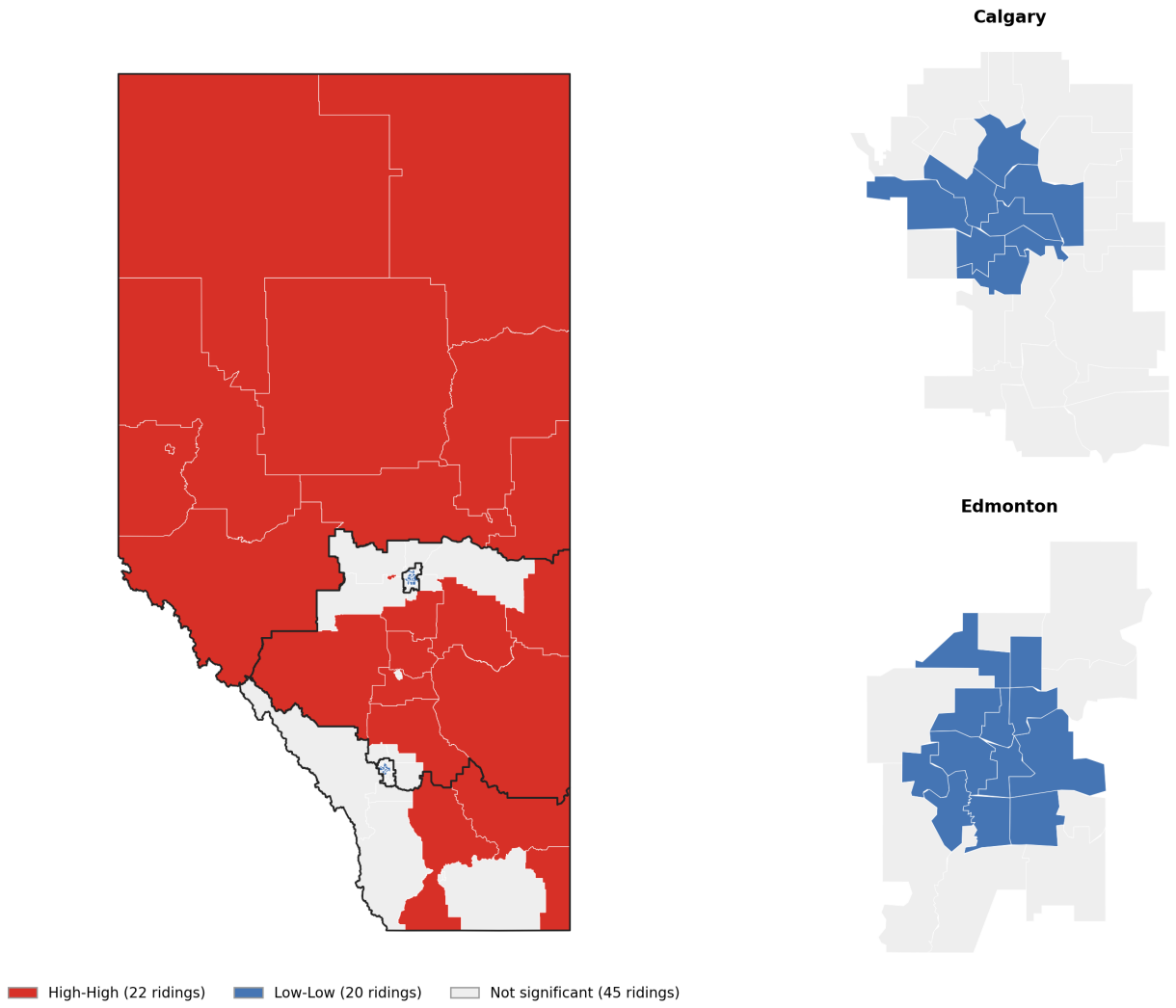


Figure 4: Significant local clusters of Option 2 support (conditional permutation, $p < 0.05$), with Calgary and Edmonton enlarged. Grey ridings show no pattern beyond chance.

4.2 Questions 1 to 9

Questions 1 to 5, which focused on immigration control, won majorities province-wide and questions 6 to 9, around provincial power, did not (Table 2). Support ranged from 58.1% on Q5 Citizenship to vote to 25.1% on Q10 Separation process, which was 17 points below any other question.

Table 2: Province-wide support, riding-level range and spatial clustering for each question. Support is Yes for questions 1 to 9 and Option 2 for Question 10. Moran's I uses shared-border neighbours; every value has p=0.0001. 'Within regions' is Moran's I after removing regional means.

Question	Support (%)	Ridings > 50%	Lowest (%)	Highest (%)	Moran's I	I within regions
Q1 Immigration control	54.9	48	27.5	78.5	0.72	0.17
Q2 Program eligibility	52.5	42	24.7	76.8	0.72	0.18
Q3 Residency wait	53.1	43	25.7	77.3	0.73	0.19
Q4 Health/education fee	51.8	41	24.5	76.3	0.70	0.15

Table 2: Province-wide support, riding-level range and spatial clustering for each question. Support is Yes for questions 1 to 9 and Option 2 for Question 10. Moran's I uses shared-border neighbours; every value has p=0.0001. 'Within regions' is Moran's I after removing regional means.

Question	Support (%)	Ridings > 50%	Lowest (%)	Highest (%)	Moran's I	I within regions
Q5 Citizenship to vote	58.1	62	30.5	81.5	0.72	0.17
Q6 Provinces pick judges	45.4	33	19.5	74.5	0.72	0.15
Q7 Abolish Senate	47.3	34	22.0	75.0	0.72	0.15
Q8 Opt out with funding	42.4	27	17.2	69.3	0.73	0.15
Q9 Provincial paramountcy	44.2	31	18.5	72.5	0.74	0.15
Q10 Separation process	25.1	2	9.3	50.9	0.73	0.11

Within every question, ridings disagreed widely, by 42 to 55 percentage points between the lowest and highest riding (Figure 5). In every case the city ridings sit at the low end and the North and Central ridings at the high end. What changes from question to question is where 50% falls in that ordering: questions 1 to 5 won a majority in 41 to 62 ridings, questions 6 to 9 in 27 to 34, and Question 10 in 2.

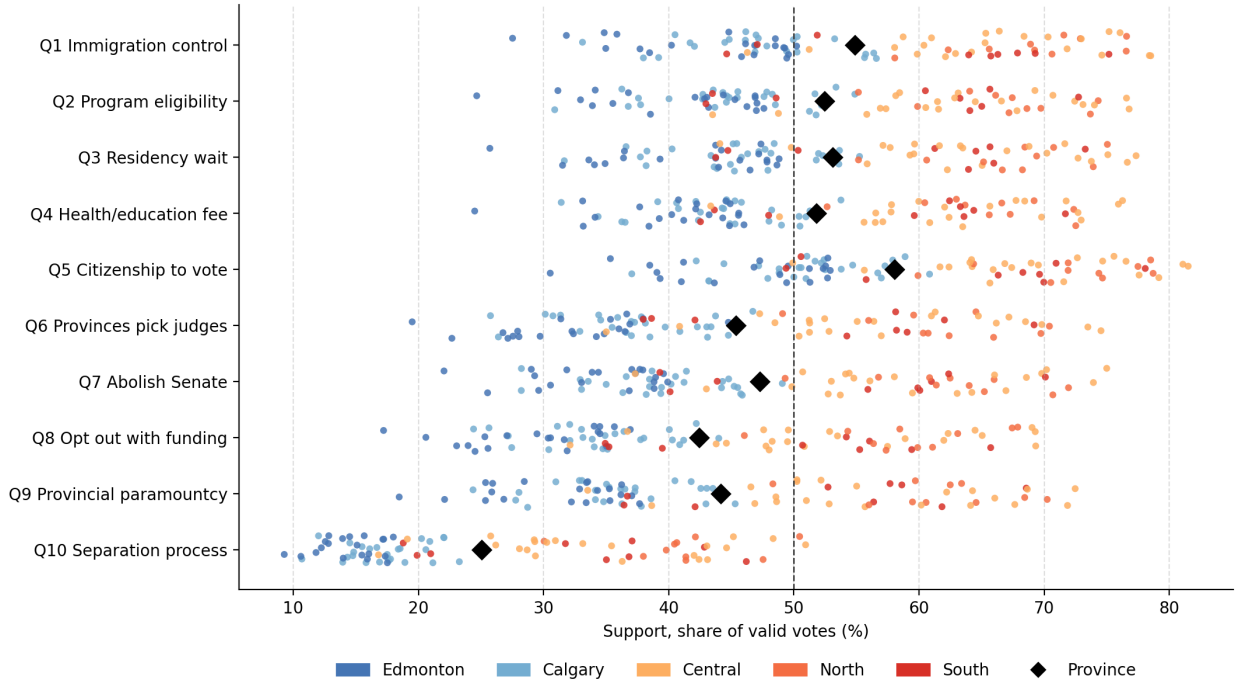


Figure 5: Support on every question in every riding, coloured by region. Diamonds are the province-wide results; the dashed line is 50%.

Mapping these results demonstrates similar geographic divisions across all ten questions (Figure 6). Every pair of questions correlates at 0.96 or higher across ridings, and a single shared pattern accounts for 99% of the variation in support across all ten questions. Every question is clustered to the same degree (Moran's I from 0.70 to 0.74), and on every question most of that clustering is regional (0.11 to 0.19 within regions). The regions keep the same order on all ten questions (Figure 7): the North gave the most support and Edmonton the least, the gap between them was 26 to 31 points, and Calgary was 3 to 5 points more supportive than Edmonton throughout.

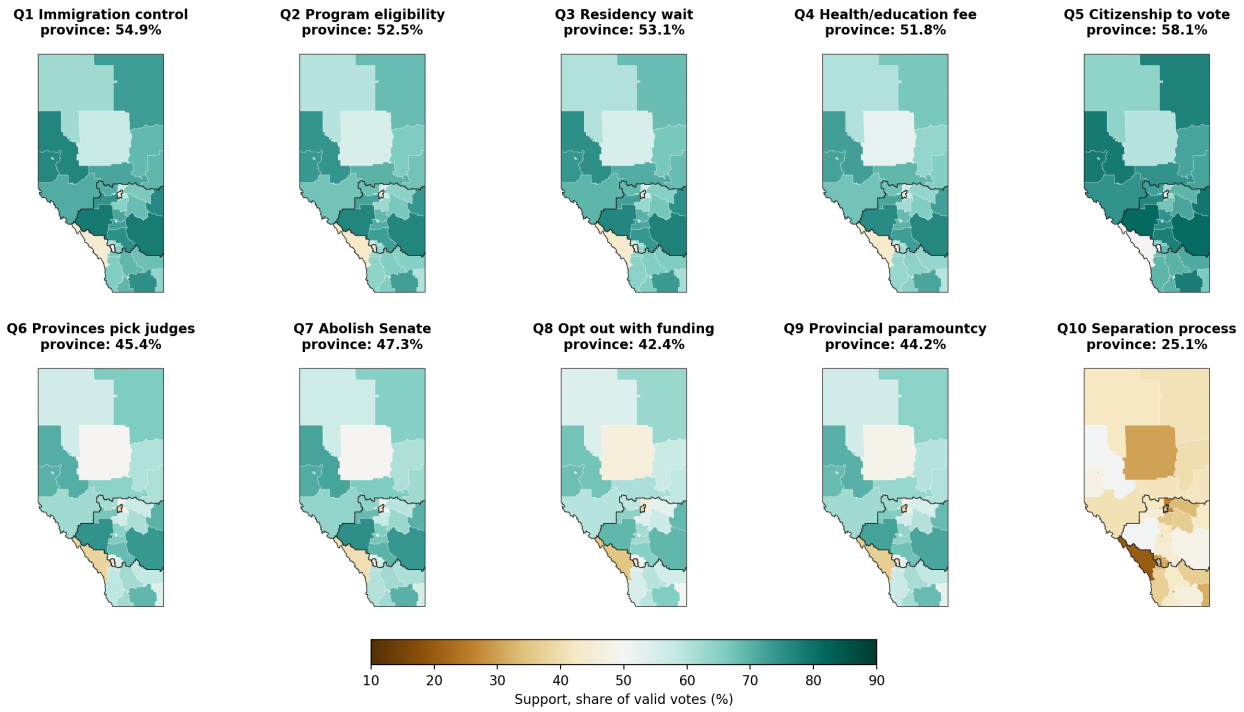


Figure 6: Support for each question by riding, on a common scale. Green is majority support and brown majority opposition.

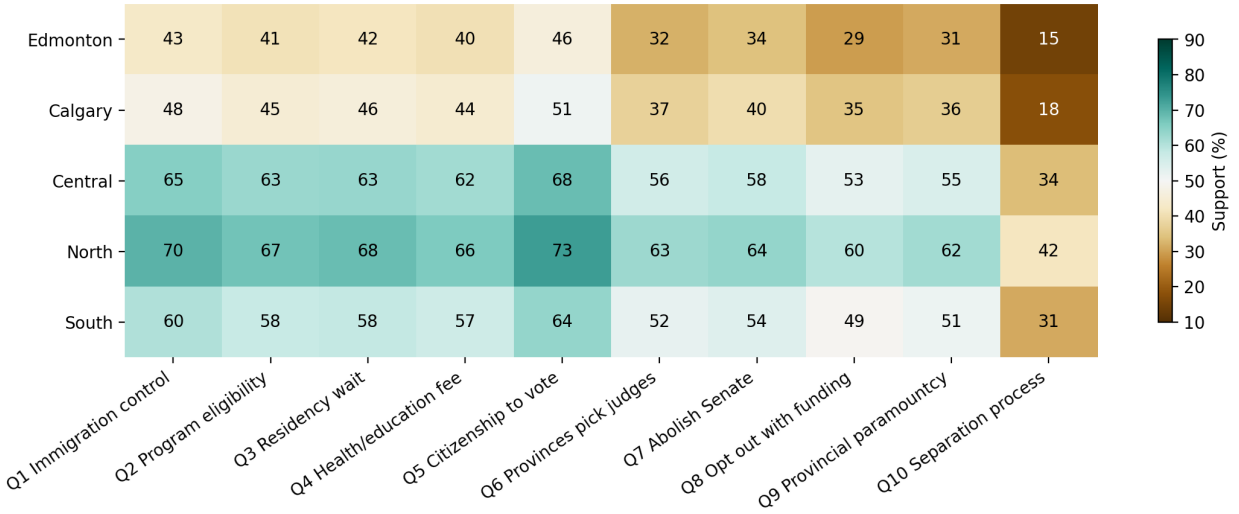


Figure 7: Support by region and question, from summed votes.

The two groups of questions differ slightly in where their support came from: the gap between the immigration and voting questions and the constitutional questions was widest in Edmonton (10.7 points) and Calgary (9.7) and narrowest in the North (6.9). City voters were relatively more open to the immigration proposals than to constitutional change.

4.3 Provincial Party Affiliation

The single geography of the referendum is close to the geography of the UCP vote. Across ridings, every question's support correlates with the party's 2023 share at 0.93 to 0.95 (Figure 8). The questions differ in where they sit against that vote. The immigration and voting questions ran close to it: their support exceeded the UCP share in 35 to 77 of 87 ridings. The constitutional questions ran below it, exceeding the UCP share in at most 12 ridings and falling 5 to 10 points short on average. Question 10 fell below the UCP share in all 87 ridings, by 27 points on average.

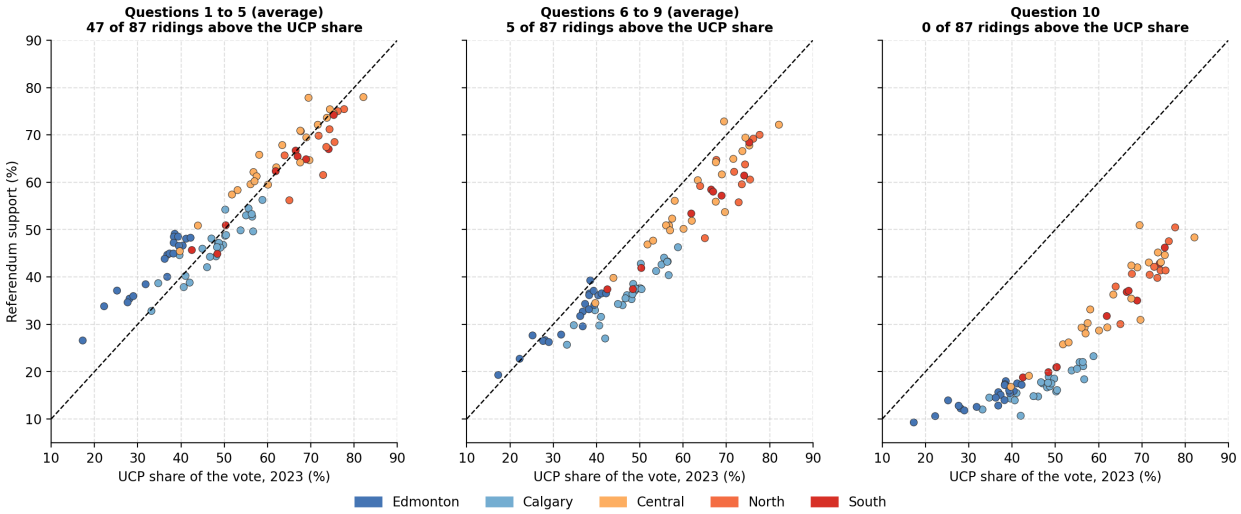


Figure 8: Referendum support against the UCP's 2023 share, by riding. The dashed line marks equal values; points above it are ridings where the question did better than the UCP had.

The regional breakdown shows where each group of questions found support beyond the party (Figure 9). In Edmonton, where the UCP took 34% of the 2023 vote, the immigration and voting questions ran 6 to 12 points above it: these proposals drew support from well outside the governing party's electorate. Elsewhere they ran within a few points of the UCP vote. The constitutional questions fell short of the UCP vote in every region. Question 10 fell short by 20 to 31 points, most in Calgary and the North. In the North, where the UCP took 72% of the vote, separation drew 42%.

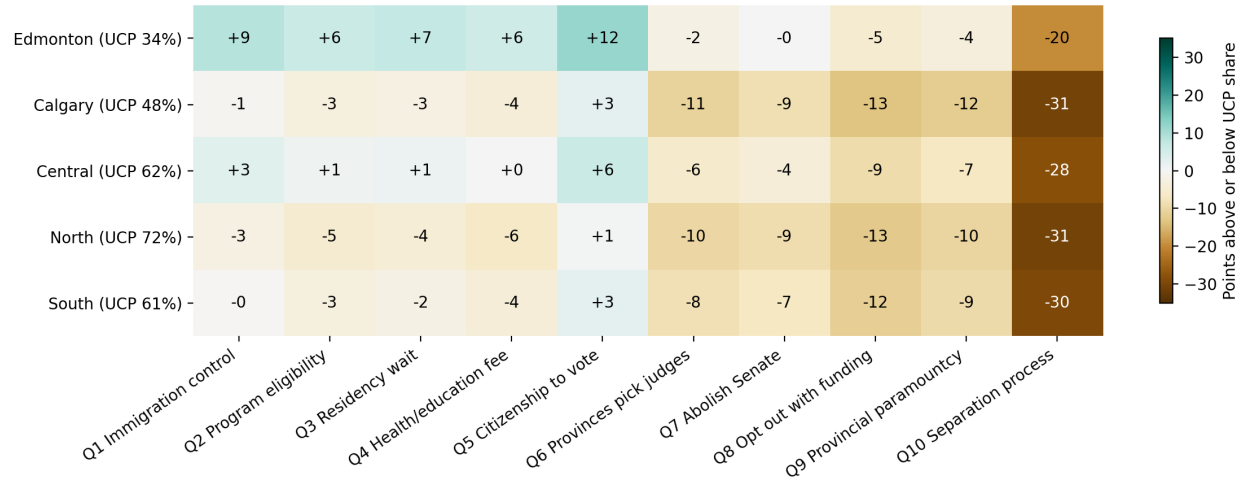


Figure 9: Referendum support minus the UCP's 2023 share, by region and question, from summed votes. Regions are labelled with the UCP's 2023 share.

This disconnect between party alignment and referendum results demonstrates broader political sentiments within the province. Separation and constitutional amendments remain unpopular, even among UCP supporters, but do align with federal political beliefs, where Alberta predominately voted Conservative for the 2025 general election (Elections Canada 2025). The party vote does not, however, account for all of the referendum's geography. The 2023 UCP share explains 92% of the variation in Question 10 support across ridings, but the remainder is still spatially clustered (Moran's $I = 0.36$, $p = 0.0001$). Neighbouring ridings miss the party-based prediction in the same direction, so some of the regional pattern in the separation vote is not a reflection of 2023 partisanship. The other referendum questions predict Question 10 better (97%, with leftover clustering of 0.19).

Question 10 drew from the same places as every other question, but its support was not a fixed fraction. In the 27 ridings where all nine other proposals won a majority, Option 2 ranged from 30.9% to 50.9%, with a median of 41.4%; only 2 crossed 50%. In the 24 ridings where none of the nine won a majority, almost all in the two cities, the median was 14.2%.

The carry-over ratio shows how this ceiling varied (Figure 10). The median Edmonton riding gave Question 10 0.38 times its average support for the other proposals, and the median Calgary riding 0.42, against 0.53 in Central, 0.57 in the South and 0.62 in the North. Across ridings, carry-over rose almost in step with support for the other proposals (correlation 0.92). Where the other proposals were popular, Question 10 kept more than half of their level of support; where they were unpopular, it kept well under half. Even in its strongest territory, separation fell well short of the majorities the other proposals won.

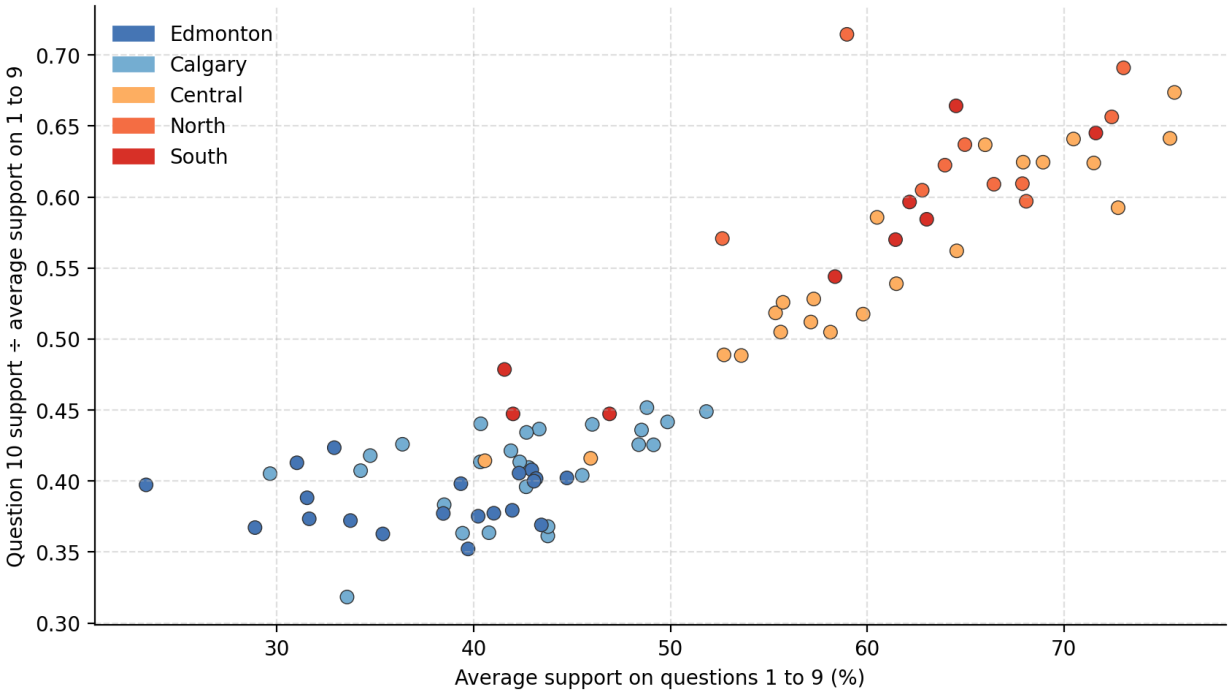


Figure 10: Question 10 support as a fraction of each riding's average support on questions 1 to 9, against that average.

Because Question 10 tracked the other questions so closely, the ridings that departed from that relationship are informative. A riding's average support on questions 1 to 9 accounts for 97% of the variation in Question 10 support (Figure 11). The departures are small, mostly within a few points, but they are not random: they cluster geographically (Moran's I = 0.19, p = 0.0016).

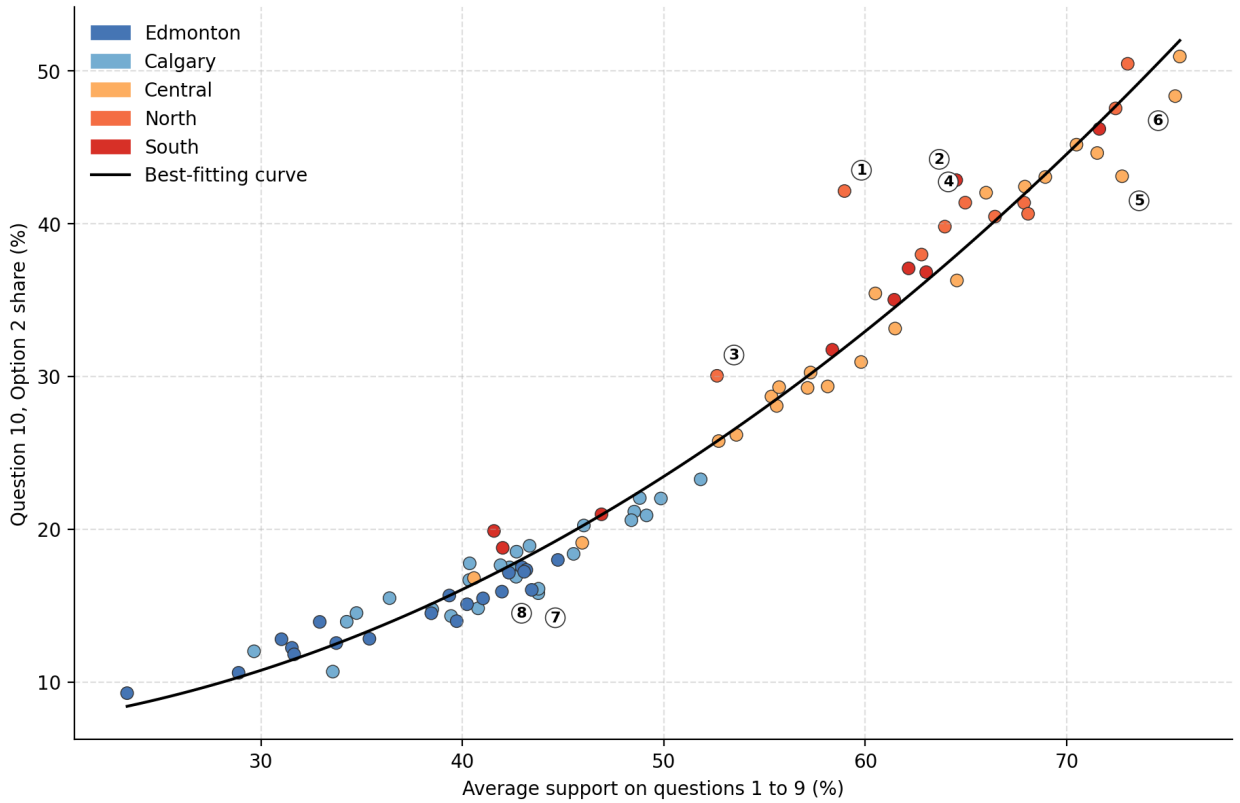


Figure 11: Question 10 support against average support on questions 1 to 9, with a quadratic fit. Numbered ridings are the four furthest above and below the curve, listed in Table 3.

Table 3: Ridings whose Question 10 result departed most from what their answers to questions 1 to 9 predict. Positive values mean more Option 2 support than predicted.

Label	Riding	Region	Departure (points)
1	Peace River	North	+10.3
2	Cardston-Siksika	South	+4.9
3	Lesser Slave Lake	North	+4.3
4	Bonnyville-Cold Lake-St. Paul	North	+2.9
5	Vermilion-Lloydminster-Wainwright	Central	-5.0
6	Drumheller-Stettler	Central	-3.3
7	Calgary-Cross	Calgary	-2.8
8	Calgary-North	Calgary	-2.5

The largest positive departure was Peace River, where Option 2 ran 10.3 points above prediction, followed by Cardston-Siksika (South, +4.9), Lesser Slave Lake (North, +4.3), Bonnyville-Cold Lake-St. Paul (North, +2.9). On average, northern ridings gave separation 2.2 points more than their other answers implied, and southern ridings 1.3 points more (Figure 12). The largest negative departures were in east-central Alberta, led by Vermilion-Lloydminster-Wainwright (-5.0 points), and in a group of Calgary ridings. These ridings stopped further short of separation than their answers on the other nine questions would predict.

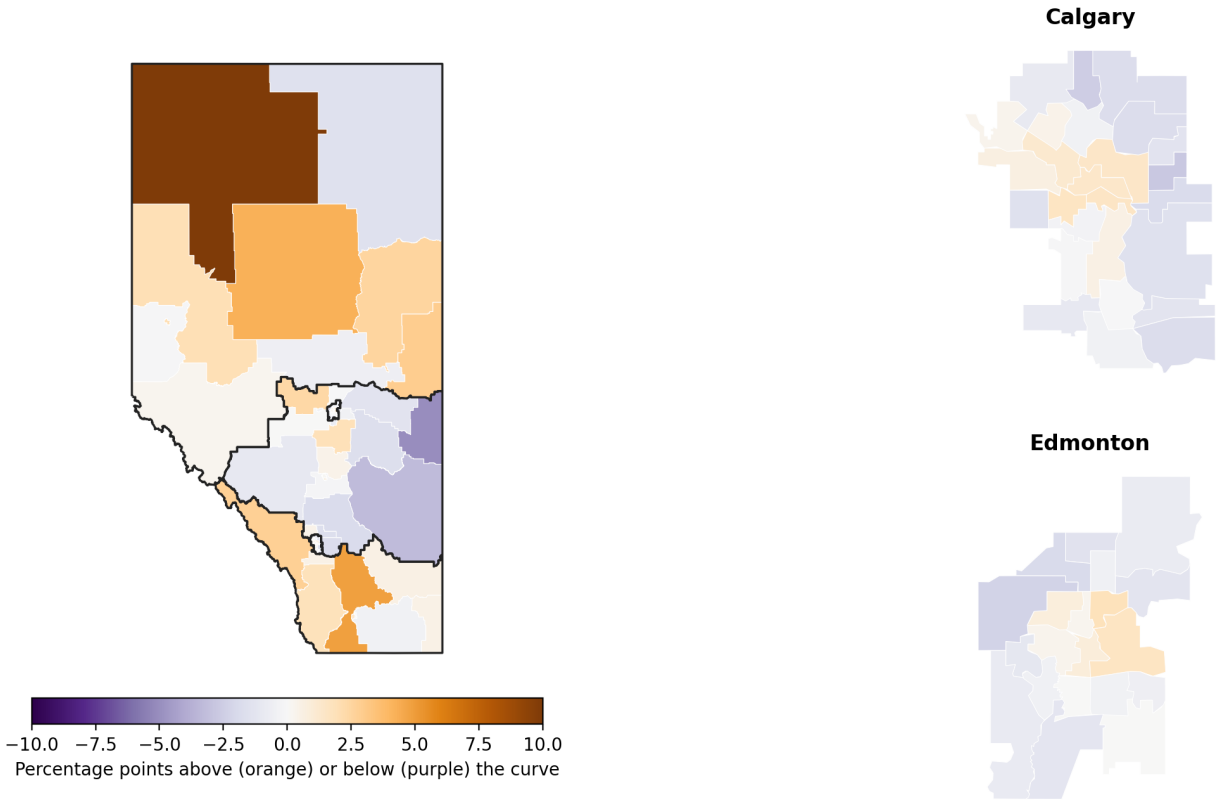


Figure 12: Departure of each riding's Question 10 result from the fitted curve, with Calgary and Edmonton enlarged. Orange ridings gave Option 2 more support than their other answers predict; purple ridings gave less.

Past elections only faintly mark these ridings (Table 4). Departures were larger where the Alberta Independence Party did better in 2019 (correlation 0.27 across 63 ridings, p = 0.033), although that party never won more than 2.5% of a riding's vote (Figure 13). They were also larger where the UCP's share rose more, or fell less, between 2019 and 2023 (correlation 0.25, p = 0.018), the first election after Danielle Smith became party leader. The UCP's 2023 share itself was unrelated to the departures, so the association is with the movement of the party's vote, not its level. Both correlations are weak, each accounting for less than a tenth of the variation, and they are two significant results among five uncorrected tests. They suggest where to look rather than explain the departures; doing so would require data on who lives in each riding.

Table 4: Correlation between each riding's Question 10 departure and election measures, with two-sided permutation p-values. Ridings without a candidate from the party are excluded.

Measure	Ridings	Correlation with departure	p
Alberta Independence Party share, 2019	63	+0.27	0.033
Independence parties' share, 2023	15	-0.16	0.502
Freedom Conservative Party share, 2019	24	-0.20	0.224
Change in UCP share, 2019 to 2023	87	+0.25	0.018
UCP share, 2023	87	+0.09	0.392

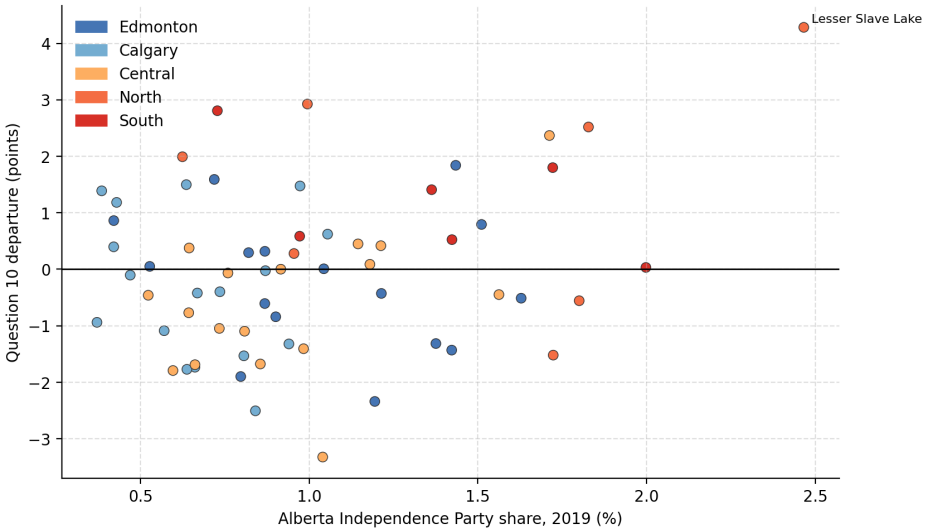


Figure 13: Question 10 departure against the Alberta Independence Party's 2019 share, in the 63 ridings where it ran.

5 Discussion

The analysis of the Alberta referendum results reveals the political divides among Albertans, particularly along location and provincial political affiliation. The Central, North, and South regions had significantly higher support compared to Calgary and Edmonton; similarly, ridings that supported the UCP and the Alberta Independence party also had significantly stronger support. This divide further reflects the alienation of these populations, specifically in response to the NDP's "post-rural" policies. Epp (2019) argues that the Albertan rural political identity is fueled by resentment and grievances towards a fluidly constructed other, as provincial governments increasingly seek to curry favour in the province's centre. "[A] a politics of grievance," he warns, "can easily make rural people the kindling in someone else's fire."

The UCP have acknowledged the power of this base as part of their current power. Less than a month after the referendum, the party has faced criticism around the new electoral boundaries and the creation of new urban-rural hybrid ridings, including accusations of gerrymandering ahead of the upcoming election in 2027 (Johnson 2026). The referendum results also reinforce how heavily the UCP has aligned itself with these rural politics, particularly in regards to constitutional amendments (Figure 5).

Even with contention from the metropolitan ridings, the results from questions 1-5 reflect the province's conservative lean outside of federalism. Alberta's responses to controlling immigration and restricting access to public services for non-citizens represent broader anti-immigrant sentiments that strongly align with the federal Conservative party and the greater polarisation occurring on a national level around immigration and the economy (Wherry 2026).

The results of the Alberta referendum has been framed as a decisive victory, particularly in response to the radical base that Smith has been accused of exclusively catering to by running the referendum in the first place. The response from the separatist faction within the party has been to try and push for a leadership review, with the belief that Albertan independence is possible with the correct leadership and enough time Markusoff (2026). Smith, on her part, has stated there will not be another referendum during her tenure as premier and that she will act on the questions that had majority interest (Dryden 2026). The results of the referendum itself are complicated by the phrasing of the questions and the fact that the results are not legally binding - how these factors may have additionally influenced voting behaviors is unknown. Comparing the referendum results to other polling may offer a more robust representation of Albertan sentiment towards these topics.

The referendum provides insight into the specific cultural moment in Alberta; however, how the province has got to this state is not fully explored. Further research opportunities includes studying the history of the conservative parties of the 2020s, as well as examining economic and demographic data during and after the COVID pandemic.

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